him as A.A. Desanaigue who had earlier been an agent at Tuticorin for a Colombo cattle importer, the police claimed that his seafaring knowledge was zero, given that his experience was limited to voyages between Tuticorin and Colombo.[157]

Despite the business adversities it faced on a day-to-day basis, SSNCo did not give up on training. In August 1909, even as a life-or-death battle was on, an Indian Students' Association Fund was opened with Pandithurai Thevar contributing Rs 1,000 and promising to collect more.[158] The objective was to send apprentices abroad for training in shipbuilding and navigation. The company also planned The Indian Marine Scholarship Fund —it is not clear if it was a different fund—to be invested in the company's shares which would go towards scholarship grants.[159]

Towards the end of 1909, S.D. Krishna Aiyangar issued an advertisement stating that the company was receiving many applications for training and announced that this was 'the very foundation of success for the shipping industry of India'. He further added that 'India was once famous for her ships, and her sons are excellent sea-men even to-day. The organization of shipping industry and the introduction of shipbuilding in the land will provide the means of livelihood for a large number of poor Indian families besides placing the seaborne trade and commerce of India on a more advantageous basis.' He therefore called for a fund to be raised through the sale of one-rupee tickets and donations.[160] Unfortunately nothing came of this far-sighted, if idealistic, initiative. When even shares, the bread and butter of the company, remained to be fully paid after initial allotment, it was little wonder that the scholarship fund failed to elicit a response.

## Keir Hardie Sails Swadeshi

1907 ended on a high note with the Swadeshi company receiving an unexpected boost. British Labour Party MP Keir Hardie's brief visit to Tuticorin in November 1907 had a tonic effect on the movement. A founder of the Labour Party, Hardie combined radicalism and socialism. An important voice on Indian affairs in the British Parliament, he was critical